

Which UPS is for me?		
	Single computer protection	Mission-critical applications
You need	Protection for a single computer comprising a monitor, system unit, keyboard and mouse, for example, a 1 or 2 GHz processor-based machine with a 20 GB hard disk, a CD/DVD-ROM drive, 256 to 512 MB of RAM and a 17-inch monitor	Protection for a server that needs to be continually running with mission-critical applications, for example, a 1 GHz-processor, with up to 1 GB of RAM, up to four SCSI hard disks, a CD-ROM drive, backup device and a 17-inch monitor
Look for	An offline or line-interactive UPS with a VA rating of 450 to 650 VA and with a backup time of 10 minutes	An online UPS with a VA rating of at least 1 KVA and with a backup time of 10 minutes. It should also support remote monitoring through a serial port with alarms and indicators in case of power anomalies

By the power of a UPS!

A UPS is specified by its VA rating. This is a measure of the amount of power the UPS can provide and it usually lasts for about 10 to 12 minutes. Therefore, if a 500 VA UPS is loaded with equipment that draws 500 VA of power, it will last for about 10 minutes. If the load is halved to 250 VA, the backup time will increase to about 16 to 18 minutes. This is assuming, of course, that the battery is fully charged and functional. Hence, when buying a UPS system, you should first ascertain what equipment is going to be connected to it and more importantly, what kind of power conditions you want to protect your equipment from.

UPS systems should be used to power only the most critical parts of your computer (see box, 'Choosing the Right UPS Rating'). By connecting only the critical components, you will not overload your UPS and will therefore have longer backup times in the event of a power failure. Try not to connect peripherals such as printers or scanners to your system as these draw considerable power. Also, use the time the UPS is on battery not so much to work as to save your work and shut down the system normally.

■ **Input voltage range:** This is the range beyond which the UPS is going to deliver power through its batteries. The greater the range the UPS can handle, the more versatile its power protection. Look for a voltage range between 150 and 270 volts.

■ **VA rating:** This is a rating of the power that can be provided by the UPS. You should choose the rating on the

basis of the power requirements of the equipment you are going to connect to the UPS. As a rule of thumb, a 1 GHz processor-based machine with a 20 GB hard disk, a CD-ROM drive and a 17-inch colour monitor would require a 500 VA UPS.

■ **Backup time:** This is the specified time for which the UPS can provide power from its battery for a given load. Look for a backup time of at least 10 minutes at maximum load.

■ **Switching/transfer time:** Used interchangeably, switching or transfer time is the time taken by the UPS to switch from normal delivery power mode to battery mode when it detects power anomalies. Look for transfer times under 5 milliseconds.

■ **Alarms and connectivity:** Most UPS systems have LEDs on the front panel that indicate the state of the UPS' batteries and the condition of the input and output power. This visual indication of its operation is important especially during power failures—look for a UPS that features these indicators.

■ **Charging time:** This is the time taken to charge the UPS batteries from a completely drained state to a fully charged condition. This should be between 4 and 6 hours.

I have the power

They say that an ounce of prevention is better than a pound of cure. Invest in a suitable power protection system to safeguard your equipment and data, or else be a powerless spectator when your system gets zapped!

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